

c is remarkably solid, internally consistent or coherent—the internal pattern and dependency are heavy, which enhances the group’s credibility as a line of transmission.

And how about between groups? It is the comparatively high level of pattern and dependency that allows us to group a,b,f,g,i and to say that together they form a text-type (call it ‘Koine’). The same obtains for d,e,h (call it ‘Andreas’). In contrast to those eight, c is independent of them all, as shown by the lack of pattern and dependency. c and ‘Koine’ agree against ‘Andreas’ over 100 times, while c and ‘Andreas’ agree against ‘Koine’ over 100 times as well. The complete roster of ‘Koine’ and ‘Andreas’ agrees against c eleven times. I submit that the most reasonable explanation for the evidence before us is that c is the common denominator; it is the core of the transmission from which all the others departed, at different times and different ways.

So what do pattern and dependency tell us? They permit us to identify groups, or families, of MSS. They also define the level of internal consistency of each group. The lack of pattern and dependency permits us to identify independent lines of transmission. All MSS received common influence from the Original, but evidently independent lines of transmission cannot represent the Original equally. So what do we do when confronted with several such lines? Or, to take a concrete case, how can we choose between ‘Koine’, ‘Andreas’ and ‘Complutensian’ in Revelation? If we follow two against one, we will have a ‘majority’ text—as a guess, it will be at least 90% Complutensian (it is seldom alone).¹ (From my point of view, that would be a very good Text!)

There is not a single clear three-way split in the whole book, and only one that might be said to come fairly close (at 15:4). What does the lack of three-way splits tell us? It tells us that the three groups are not equally independent. It tells us that the Complutensian is the most independent of the three—independent with reference to the other two! Since all three are dependent on the Original, can we determine which one is most dependent, and therefore closest to the Original? If the evidence points to Complutensian as the common denominator, then the other two groups are at least partly dependent upon it; this would mean that Complutensian lies between them and the Original, and is therefore closest to the Original.

¹ Just for the record, the *TuT* edition uses a “relative majority”. To arrive at that “*rM*” they added NA²⁸ as a fourth line, but also used ‘internal’ considerations. They followed ‘Koine’ 98 times, ‘Complutensian’ 95 times, ‘Andreas’ 79 times and NA²⁸ 41 times (extracted from twelve combinations). They followed ‘Koine’ by itself eleven times, the only line so treated.